Julien Clifford

PRINCIPAL SOFTWARE ENGINEER

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Over 15 years building production software. Founder of Atelier Actara, a platform that manages fashion show production, where I build web, iOS, and Android clients on one GraphQL API and run the business. Spent two years at Invisible Technologies delivering to OpenAI, Microsoft, Google, and Amazon, and built the QA function there. Engineers have reported to me at Chess.com, Invisible, and Amplify Life Insurance, and I have stood up engineering teams and chosen their stacks. Before that, energy and industrial software at Landdox, Quorum, and BSD Consulting.

EXPERIENCE

Dec 2022 to present

Atelier Actara

Founder and Principal Engineer / Remote

A platform that manages fashion show production, covering casting, lineup, venues, guest lists, and check-in, built alongside the roles below and used for three shows.

- Wrote an Elixir and Phoenix back end split into domain apps behind one GraphQL API, a React and TypeScript web client, Postgres, and hosting on Google Cloud and Fly.io.
- Built a multi-tenant permission model under which agencies, brands, and venues work one show without seeing each other's data.
- Put native iOS and Android apps and a command-line admin tool on that same API, so business rules live in one place.
- Directed AI coding agents working from conventions, product rules, and design rules I wrote, plus custom skills, hooks, and pre-ship checks, one of which rejects copy that reads as machine-written.
- Set pricing, wrote a financial plan, and designed the brand, design system, and merchandise.

June 2025 to Apr 2026

Chess.com

Technical Product Manager / Remote

- Wrote specs engineers built from, refining loose product requirements into scoped, estimated work.
- Led two engineering teams through new-player onboarding work, from spec to release, for millions of new players.
- Added onboarding and activation metrics the team uses to judge funnel changes.
- Built a configuration layer for onboarding, where which steps a new player sees depends on that player's details, and ran experiments on those variations.
- Managed three engineers and owned the new-user experience roadmap and release plan.

Mar 2023 to Feb 2025

Invisible Technologies

Principal Engineer and Partner / Remote

An AI services company delivering to OpenAI, Microsoft, Google, and Amazon.

- Set up QA: testing standards, documentation, and an automated suite that took coverage from zero to 85 percent.
- Designed and built a terms-of-service and statement-of-work system: a data model and rules for each client contract, with in-app time tracking against those agreements.
- Managed two engineering teams in parallel, four engineers reporting to me, owning delivery, hiring, and performance for both.
- Ran technical hiring, sourcing outside and promoting from within.
- Worked in Python, Django, and Flask on services behind client work.

Sep 2021 to June 2022

Amplify Life Insurance

Staff Engineer / Remote

Stood up a life insurer's whole US engineering team: hiring, stack, and process.

- Replaced a legacy stack with a company-wide Elixir API server and Postgres database, with continuous integration and tests from the first commit.
- Built React and Redux front ends against that API.
- Wrote the team's code review policy, and reviewed both front end and back end.
- Managed three engineers, and ran sprint planning, scoping, and retrospectives.

June 2021 to Sep 2021

Vic.ai

Senior Elixir Engineer / Remote

- Shipped core Elixir for an early-stage startup, including a CSV importer that handled arbitrary client file formats, and introduced retrospectives, documentation, and project planning.

Oct 2020 to May 2021

Quorum Software

Senior Software Engineer / Houston, Texas

Enterprise software for the energy industry.

- Integrated Landdox into Quorum's enterprise codebase after the acquisition.

June 2015 to Oct 2020

Landdox

Full Stack Engineer, second engineer hired / Houston, Texas

Land management software for oil and gas, acquired by Quorum Software in 2020.

- Planned and led major features: mapping, bulk data import, and a system that generated payment checks.
- Worked across stack and infrastructure: Elixir, Node, Angular, React, AWS, and Terraform.
- Interviewed and hired engineers, and joined sales calls to answer technical questions.

EARLIER

2014 to 2015

BSD Consulting / Full Stack Engineer
Sole engineer on a web platform for pipeline data, server and client, from prototype through delivery.

2010 to 2014

Conrad Blucher Institute / Undergraduate Research Assistant
Built mobile mapping apps on Perl servers: land surveying tools with survey-grade GPS and RTK collection, funded in part by NOAA; Transit Time, a ship channel app with NOAA that won the 2013 Undergraduate Research Symposium; and Weather on Wheels, a road trip app that warns of storms along a route.

2012 and 2013

Esri and Shell Oil Company / Technical Marketing and Geomatics internships
Geoprocessing scripts for disaster response at Esri; Python automation for spatial data pipelines and sonar rasters at Shell, plus seven days at sea on a hydrographic survey.

TECHNICAL

BACKEND	Elixir and Phoenix, OTP, Absinthe GraphQL, Ecto, Python, Django, Flask, Node, PHP, Perl, PostgreSQL
FRONTEND	React, Redux, React Router, Angular, TypeScript, MUI, Tailwind
PLATFORM	AWS, Google Cloud, Terraform, Docker, Fly.io, CI and CD pipelines
DELIVERY	Scrum and sprint planning, release planning, code review standards, test automation (ExUnit, Playwright, Vitest), technical hiring

EDUCATION

2009 to 2014

Texas A&M University, Corpus Christi / BS, Geographic Information Science and Geomatics
Outstanding Islander award, 2013.